
A COLLECTION OF RECIPES & KITCHEN NOTES

Joseph's Recipe Book

Compiled from the Claude archives · July 2026

All measurements in grams.

Weigh everything — if you're not weighing, you're guessing.

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01 · NY-Style Pizza Dough (5 × 12" Balls)

65% hydration with vital wheat gluten for that NY chew. Sized to match the other doughs in this book (1 kg flour, 5 balls). Built for the Ooni Volt 2.

Yield: 5 dough balls (~342 g each) · Active: ~30 min · Cold ferment: 24-72 hrs

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · FREEZER-FRIENDLY · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Bread flour	1000 g
Vital wheat gluten (1-2%)	10 g (up to 20 g for more extensibility)
Water (total, split below)	650 g
Salt	22 g
Sugar	20 g
Instant dry yeast	3 g (reduce to ~1.5 g for 72-hr ferment)
Olive oil	15 g

Method

1. Combine flour, vital wheat gluten, sugar, and yeast in a large bowl.
2. Add ~90% of the water (~585 g) and mix until no dry flour remains.
3. Dissolve the salt in the remaining ~65 g of water, pour into the dough, and mix by squeezing and folding.
4. Add the olive oil and mix until fully absorbed.
5. Cover and rest 20 minutes.
6. Stretch & fold, Round 1: perform 4 folds (N-S-E-W). Cover and rest 20-30 min.
7. Stretch & fold, Round 2: repeat 4 folds. Cover and rest 20-30 min.
8. Stretch & fold, Round 3: repeat 4 folds. Rest 20-30 min. Do a 4th round only if the dough still feels slack.
9. Transfer to a lightly oiled container. Cold ferment 24-48 hours (up to 72 hrs max — reduce yeast to 0.3% if going 72).
10. Divide into 5 balls (~342 g each); tighten each by folding edges underneath.
11. Optional freeze: freeze immediately after balling to prevent overfermentation. Wrap individually in plastic, then bag. To use: thaw overnight in fridge, then rest 2-3 hrs at room temp.
12. Bake: preheat Ooni Volt 2 stone at least 45 min at 750-800°F. Stretch to 12" (never roll). Sauce and top sparingly. Bake 4-6 min, rotating halfway. Optional: broil final 30-45 sec for NY-style char.

Notes

Yeast: 3 g works for 24-48 hr cold ferments; drop to ~1.5 g for 72 hrs to avoid overproofing. Vital wheat gluten: 10 g = moderate chew, up to 20 g = extra-extensible dough (easier to stretch cold-proofed balls). Baker's percentages (vs 1000 g flour): water 65% · salt 2.2% · sugar 2% · oil 1.5% · yeast 0.3%.

02 · NY-Style Sourdough Pizza Dough (5 × 12" Balls)

Same NY-style target as the yeasted dough — thin, chewy, char-flecked — but leavened entirely with an active sourdough starter. Slower rise, more complex tangy flavor. Built for the Ooni Volt 2.

Yield: 5 dough balls (~343 g each) · Active: ~30 min · Bulk: 4-6 hrs · Cold ferment: 24-72 hrs

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · FREEZER-FRIENDLY · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Bread flour	900 g
Active sourdough starter (100% hydration, fed & peaked)	200 g
Water (additional, beyond starter)	550 g
Salt	25 g
Olive oil	20 g
Sugar (optional, helps browning)	10 g
Vital wheat gluten (optional, for NY chew)	10 g

Method

1. Feed your starter 4-8 hrs ahead so it's active and at peak (doubled, domed, floats in water) when you mix.
2. Combine bread flour, vital wheat gluten, and sugar in a large bowl.
3. Add starter and ~90% of the water (~495 g). Mix until no dry flour remains; rest 20-30 min (autolyse).
4. Dissolve salt in the remaining water (~55 g), add to the dough, and mix by squeezing and folding.
5. Add the olive oil and mix until fully absorbed.
6. Bulk ferment at room temp 4-6 hrs: 4 stretch-and-folds (N-S-E-W) every 30-45 min for the first 2-3 hrs, then leave undisturbed. Expect ~30-50% rise, not a full double.
7. Cold ferment 24-72 hrs in a lightly oiled container. Longer (48-72 hrs) = more tang and better browning.
8. Divide into 5 balls (~343 g each); tighten by folding the edges underneath.
9. Optional freeze: wrap individually and bag right after balling. Thaw overnight in the fridge, then rest 2-3 hrs at room temp before stretching.
10. Bake: preheat Ooni Volt 2 stone 45+ min at 750-800°F. Stretch to 12" (never roll). Sauce and top sparingly. Bake 4-6 min, rotating halfway. Optional: broil final 30-45 sec for NY-style char.

Notes

Starter activity matters more than time — a sluggish starter needs a longer bulk ferment. If it's less active or the room's cool, extend bulk fermentation rather than rushing the cold ferment. Baker's percentages (vs 1000 g total flour incl. starter's flour): water ~65% · salt 2.5% · oil 2% · sugar 1%. No commercial yeast — an unfed starter gives a flat, dense crust.

03 · NY-Style Pizza Sauce (San Marzano)

A simple no-cook sauce that lets the San Marzano tomatoes shine — classic for a thin, crisp-crust pie. The oven does the cooking. Sized for a full 794 g Cento can.

Yield: sauce for ~4 pizzas (full can) · Active: ~5 min + 15-20 min rest

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · FREEZER-FRIENDLY · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Cento San Marzano peeled tomatoes	794 g (full can)
Garlic cloves, minced or grated	2
Extra virgin olive oil	2 tbsp (≈26 g)
Fine sea salt	1 tsp (≈6 g)
Dried oregano	1 tsp
Sugar (optional, balances acidity)	0.5 tsp
Red pepper flakes (optional)	1 pinch
Fresh basil leaves, torn (optional)	2

Method

1. Crush the tomatoes by hand or with a potato masher to your desired texture — slightly chunky is traditional for NY style.
2. Stir in garlic, olive oil, salt, oregano, and the optional sugar and pepper flakes. Mix well.
3. Rest at room temperature 15-20 minutes so the flavors meld. No cooking needed.
4. Tear in fresh basil right before using. Spread a thin layer on the dough — don't overload it.

Notes

Freezing: this batch uses the whole can, so freeze whatever you don't use right away — seasoned sauce freezes better than plain tomatoes and is ready to use once thawed. Leave basil out of the portion you're freezing; add it fresh after thawing. Freeze flat in a bag with headroom; keeps 3-4 months. Prefer a cooked sauce? Simmer everything 15-20 min instead. Nutrition per full batch: ~180-200 kcal total, mostly from the olive oil.

04 · Sourdough Bread (Bread Flour or Rye Rustic)

Your standard two-loaf sourdough, with a rustic/integral variant swapping in rye for some of the flour. Same hydration and salt ratios either way — just a different flour blend and a slightly denser crumb on the rye version.

Yield: 2 loaves · Active: ~30 min · Bulk: 4-6 hrs · Cold ferment: 12-24 hrs

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Standard (bread flour)

Ingredient	Amount
Bread flour	1000 g
Water	650-690 g (65-69%)
Salt	20-22 g
Active sourdough starter (100% hydration, fed & peaked)	200 g

Rustic/Integral variant

Ingredient	Amount
Bread flour	900 g
Rye flour	100 g
Water	650-690 g (65-69%)
Salt	20-22 g
Active sourdough starter (100% hydration, fed & peaked)	200 g

Method

1. Feed your starter 4-8 hrs ahead so it's active and at peak (doubled, domed, floats in water) when mixing.
2. Combine flour(s) with ~90% of the water until no dry flour remains. Rest 20-30 min (autolyse) — rye may look wetter/stickier here.
3. Dissolve salt in the remaining water, add along with the active starter, and mix by squeezing and folding until incorporated.
4. Bulk ferment at room temp 4-6 hrs: 4-6 stretch-and-folds or coil folds at 30-45 min intervals through the first 2-3 hrs, then leave undisturbed. Expect ~30-50% rise.
5. Divide into 2 pieces. Pre-shape into loose rounds, rest uncovered 15-20 min, then final-shape into a boule or batard.
6. Place seam-side up in a floured banneton. Cold retard in the fridge 12-24 hrs (longer = more sour, better oven spring).
7. Preheat oven to 250°C (480°F) with a Dutch oven inside for 45+ min.
8. Turn dough onto parchment, score the top, and lower into the Dutch oven. Cover and bake 20 min.
9. Remove the lid, drop oven to 230°C (450°F), and bake uncovered 20-25 min more until deep golden-brown (internal ~96-99°C/205-210°F).
10. Cool on a wire rack at least 1 hour before slicing — cutting too early gives a gummy crumb.

Notes

Rye swap: 100 g rye (10%) adds earthy flavor and a denser crumb at the same 65-69% hydration. Push to 150-200 g for more rye flavor, bumping hydration slightly since rye lacks gluten structure. Baker's %: water 65-69% · salt 2-2.2% · starter 20% (vs 1000 g total flour). Same ratios for both variants — only the flour blend changes.

05 · Sourdough Shokupan (Japanese Milk Bread)

A pillowy, cloud-like milk bread with the deep flavor and gentle tang of sourdough, built on a tangzhong starter for extra softness. A genuine two-day project — most of it is inactive fermentation time.

Yield: one 1 lb loaf (~12 slices) · Active: ~1.5 hrs · Bulk + cold ferment: overnight · Proof: 6-8 hrs · Bake: 27 min

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Tangzhong

Ingredient	Amount
All-purpose flour (11.7% protein)	20 g
Whole milk	100 g

Bread dough

Ingredient	Amount
Whole milk	60 g
Granulated sugar	30 g
Unsalted butter, sliced into thin pats	57 g
All-purpose flour (11.7% protein)	260 g
Kosher salt	6 g
Egg, large, room temp (~50 g)	1
Sourdough starter (100% hydration)	100 g
Neutral oil, for handling	as needed

Egg wash

Ingredient	Amount
Egg, large	1
Water	15 g (1 tbsp)

Method

1. Day 1 morning: feed your starter ~12 hrs before mixing — it should more than double, with bubbles distributed evenly.
2. Evening: scald 60 g milk with the sugar, stirring, until simmering and dissolved. Add sliced butter, stir until melted, transfer to the mixer bowl to cool.
3. Tangzhong: in the same pan, add the 100 g milk and sprinkle the 20 g flour over it. Cook over medium heat, stirring, until it thickens into a paste. Spread thin on a plate to cool.
4. Once the milk/butter mixture cools to 80-90°F, whisk the 260 g flour and salt separately, add to the milk mixture, mix until absorbed (dry and clumpy is fine). Cover, rest 15-20 min.
5. Add the cooled tangzhong, egg, and starter. Knead with the dough hook on speed 2 for 20 min — tacky but mostly pulling from the bowl.
6. Oil hands and counter. Shape into a ball, return to an oiled bowl, cover, rest 30 min. Do 2-3 stretch-and-folds at 30-min intervals, then refrigerate overnight.
7. Day 2: let the cold dough warm up and continue rising in a warm spot ~2 hours, until puffy (likely not doubled yet).
8. Divide into 3 portions (~220 g each), roll into balls, rest 10-15 min. Flatten, fold into thirds, flatten again, stretch lengthwise (narrower than the pan), roll into a log, place in the pan.
9. Proof in a warm, humid spot 6-8 hrs, until very puffy and risen above the rim — a press should leave a slow-springing indentation.
10. Preheat oven to 400°F (205°C) 30+ min. Brush the egg wash generously over the top and exposed sides.
11. Bake at 400°F (205°C) 7 min, then 350°F (180°C) for 20 min more, until golden and internal temp reads 190-200°F. Tent with foil if browning too fast.
12. Cool in the pan on a rack until just warm, then remove and cool completely before slicing.

Notes

Use oil rather than extra flour when handling — added flour risks a drier loaf; by day 2 very little handling aid is needed. Rising and proofing times are temperature-dependent — treat them as a guide and rely on visual cues over the clock. Less flour than the plain sourdough bread recipe, but don't expect a smaller loaf: this is an enriched dough (milk, butter, egg, sugar, plus a tangzhong paste that lets it hold extra liquid), so it rises taller per gram of flour than a lean dough does. The dome comes from steam and a fat-tenderized gluten network, not from raw flour mass.

06 · Banana Bread with Cinnamon Streusel & Toasted Pecans

Moist, warmly spiced banana bread using self-rising flour, topped with a crunchy cinnamon streusel. Salt omitted and baking soda reduced to 2 g because self-rising flour already carries leavening and salt.

Yield: one 9×5" loaf (~10 slices) · Oven: 175°C (350°F) · Bake: 60-70 min

VEGETARIAN · FREEZER-FRIENDLY

Ingredients

Batter

Ingredient	Amount
Ripe bananas, peeled & mashed (~3 medium bananas)	340 g
Unsalted butter, melted	113 g
Sugar	150 g
Plain Greek yogurt	120 g
Eggs (without shell, ~2 large)	100 g
Vanilla extract	5 g
Self-rising flour	180 g
Baking soda (reduced)	2 g
Cinnamon	3 g
Toasted pecans, chopped	90 g (80-100 g to taste)

Streusel

Ingredient	Amount
Unsalted butter, cold & cubed	45 g
All-purpose flour	60 g
Brown sugar	50 g
Cinnamon	3 g

Method

1. Preheat oven to 175°C (350°F). Grease a 9×5" loaf pan or line with parchment.
2. Streusel: combine flour, brown sugar, and cinnamon. Cut in the cold butter with fingers or a fork until coarse crumbs form. Refrigerate until needed.
3. Whisk together mashed bananas, melted butter, sugar, yogurt, eggs, and vanilla until well combined.
4. Add self-rising flour, baking soda, and cinnamon. Fold gently with a spatula until just combined — do not overmix. Fold in the pecans.
5. Pour batter into the pan and evenly sprinkle the chilled streusel on top.
6. Bake 60-70 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean. If the streusel browns too fast, tent with foil after 40 min.
7. Cool in the pan 10 minutes, then move to a wire rack to cool fully before slicing.

Notes

Self-rising swap: 1:1 by weight for all-purpose (180 g); salt omitted; baking soda cut to 2 g (reacts with the acidic bananas). Streusel keeps AP flour. Fold, don't beat — self-rising flour hates overmixing. No pecans? Swap in 90 g chocolate chips instead — fold in the same way, right at the end.

07 · Banana Pancakes

Fluffy, naturally sweet pancakes with ripe bananas. The riper the bananas (more brown spots), the better — skip the added sugar entirely if they're very ripe.

Serves: 2 · Active: ~15 min · Nutrition (approx./serving): ~380 kcal · P 12 g · C 62 g · F 9 g · Fiber 3 g

VEGETARIAN

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Ripe bananas, peeled (~2 medium bananas)	200-220 g
Large eggs	2
All-purpose flour	120 g
Milk	120 ml
Baking powder	1 tsp
Salt	0.25 tsp
Vanilla extract	1 tsp
Sugar	15 g
Butter or neutral oil (for pan)	1 tbsp

Method

1. Mash the bananas in a large bowl until mostly smooth — a few small lumps add texture.
2. Whisk in the eggs, milk, and vanilla until well combined.
3. Add flour, baking powder, salt, and sugar. Stir gently until just combined — do not overmix (overworking develops gluten and toughens them).
4. Rest the batter 5 minutes so the baking powder activates — fluffier pancakes.
5. Heat a nonstick pan over medium heat and melt the butter. Pour ~60-70 g batter per pancake. Cook until bubbles form and edges set (~2-3 min), flip, and cook 1-2 min more until golden.

Notes

Extra protein: swap 30 g of the flour for oat flour or add a scoop of vanilla protein powder. Add-ins: chocolate chips, chopped walnuts, or a pinch of cinnamon. Keep finished pancakes warm in a ~90°C oven while cooking the rest.

08 • Freezer-Friendly Apple Crisp (Air Fryer Ready)

Individually portioned apple crisps built to go straight from freezer to air fryer — no thawing needed. Good for keeping a single-serving dessert on hand without baking a whole pan. Also works portioned into loaf pans instead of ramekins.

Yield: 6-8 small portions · Active: ~20 min · Air fryer bake (from frozen): 20-25 min

VEGETARIAN • FREEZER-FRIENDLY • MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Apple filling

Ingredient	Amount
Apples, peeled, cored, thinly sliced	900 g (~6 medium)
Brown sugar	50 g (1/4 cup)
Lemon juice	15 g (1 tbsp)
Cornstarch	10 g (1 tbsp)
Cinnamon	1 tsp
Nutmeg	0.5 tsp
Salt	1 pinch

Crisp topping

Ingredient	Amount
Rolled oats	90 g (3/4 cup)
All-purpose flour	75 g (1/2 cup)
Brown sugar	100 g (1/2 cup)
Cinnamon	1 tsp
Unsalted butter, cold & cubed	90 g (6 tbsp)

Optional finish

Ingredient	Amount
Caramel sauce (whisky caramel or plain), warmed	1-2 tbsp per portion

Method

1. Toss the apple slices with lemon juice, brown sugar, cornstarch, cinnamon, nutmeg, and salt until evenly coated.
2. Make the topping: mix oats, flour, brown sugar, and cinnamon in a bowl. Cut in the cold butter with a fork or your fingers until crumbly.
3. Portion into small freezer-safe ramekins, silicone muffin molds, foil containers, or 1 lb loaf pans — about 1 cup of apple mixture per ramekin-sized portion (a loaf pan holds roughly 2-3 portions' worth).
4. Sprinkle the crisp topping generously over each portion.
5. Wrap tightly with plastic wrap and foil, or use airtight containers. Label with the date and freeze up to 3 months.
6. To bake from frozen: preheat the air fryer to 175°C (350°F). Place one frozen crisp, unwrapped, directly into the basket. (Loaf pans that don't fit the air fryer basket can bake in a regular oven at the same temperature — add 5-10 minutes since they hold more filling.)
7. Air fry 20-25 minutes, until the apples are bubbling and the topping is golden. If the topping browns too quickly, cover loosely with foil halfway through.
8. Optional: drizzle warm caramel sauce over each portion just before serving.

Notes

No thawing needed — these go straight from freezer to air fryer, which is the whole point of portioning them individually. Loaf pans work well if you'd rather serve slices than individual ramekins — same fill-and-freeze approach, just adjust bake time up slightly for the larger portion. Cornstarch matters: it keeps the filling thick and jammy instead of watery once the apples release liquid during baking. Apple choice: firmer, tart varieties (Granny Smith, Honeycrisp) hold their shape better than soft ones (Red Delicious), which can turn mushy. Caramel drizzle: the High-End Whisky Caramel Sauce in this book pairs especially well here — warm it gently before drizzling.

09 · High-End Cheesecake (Restaurant Style)

Silky, custardy, restaurant-style cheesecake, scaled for a 9" springform (about 1.27× an 8" recipe by area). The technique matters as much as the ratios: mixing slow to avoid air bubbles, baking in a water bath, and cooling gradually are what separate this from a home-style cheesecake.

Yield: one 9" cheesecake · Active: ~1 hr · Bake: 65-75 min · Chill: 12+ hrs overnight

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Crust

Ingredient	Amount
Graham crackers, Biscoff, or Oreos (filling included), crushed to crumbs	200 g
Butter, melted (or browned for deeper flavor)	90 g
Sugar	25 g
Salt	1 g

Filling

Ingredient	Amount
Cream cheese, room temp	860 g
Sour cream (or crème fraîche for a richer version)	215 g
Granulated sugar	200 g
Eggs, whole (~4 large)	200 g
Cornstarch	25 g
Lemon juice	19 g
Vanilla extract (or scraped vanilla bean)	6 g
Salt	1 g
Heavy cream (optional, for a softer texture)	75 g

Method

1. Line the bottom of a 9" springform with parchment. Wrap the outside heavily in foil for the water bath.
2. Crust: pulse crackers into fine crumbs, mix in sugar and salt, add melted butter. Press firmly into the base only. Bake at 350°F (175°C) for 10 min, then cool completely.
3. Beat cream cheese on low until smooth with no lumps — mix slow throughout; incorporating air causes cracks and grainy texture.
4. Add sugar (mix on low until integrated), then sour cream, lemon juice, vanilla, and salt. Add cornstarch and mix gently.
5. Add eggs one at a time, mixing only until just absorbed. Whisk in heavy cream last, by hand, if using. Filling should be glossy and bubble-free.
6. Lower oven to 320°F (160°C). Pour filling into the cooled crust.
7. Place the springform in a roasting pan, add hot water halfway up the sides, and bake 65-75 min, until edges are set and the center jiggles like gelatin, not liquid.
8. Turn off the oven, crack the door, and leave the cheesecake inside 1 hour.
9. Remove, cool on the counter 1 hour, then chill overnight (12 hrs min) — this slow cool-down cures the texture and prevents cracking.

Notes

Luxury tweaks: browned butter crust; crème fraîche instead of sour cream; scraped vanilla bean instead of extract; Maldon salt on top. No graham crackers or Biscoff? Oreos (crushed whole, filling included) work as a 1:1 swap for the 200 g crumbs — skip the added sugar in the crust since Oreos are already sweet, and expect a darker, more chocolate-forward base. Finishing: crème anglaise + raspberry coulis; torched top with caramel shard; black sesame praline with yuzu; or Basque-style torched top with mascarpone and honey. Storage: rest 20-30 min at room temp before serving; 4-5 days refrigerated; freezes 1-2 months.

10 · Tres Leches Cake (Bizcocho, Crema & Meringue)

A classic Puerto Rican tres leches: a light sponge soaked in a three-milk custard, finished with a baked meringue topping. Made in three stages — cake, milk soak, then meringue.

Yield: one 9×13" cake (~12 servings) · Active: ~45 min · Bake: 20 min + 5 min

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Bizcocho (sponge cake)

Ingredient	Amount
Sugar	200 g (1 cup)
Self-rising flour (Presto or similar), sifted	120 g (1 cup)
Eggs, separated into yolks and whites	5
Vanilla extract	1 tsp

Crema (tres leches soak)

Ingredient	Amount
Sweetened condensed milk (1 can)	397 g (14 oz)
Evaporated milk (1 can)	354 g (12 oz)
Regular milk (measured using the empty evaporated milk can)	354 g (12 oz)
Egg yolks	3
Vanilla extract	1 tsp

Topping (meringue)

Ingredient	Amount
Egg whites	3
Sugar	200 g (1 cup)
Vanilla extract	1 tsp

Method

1. Bizcocho: in a bowl, beat the egg whites until stiff, snowy peaks form.
2. Add the sugar to the whipped whites, then fold in the egg yolks, vanilla, and finally the sifted flour, mixing gently to keep the batter airy.
3. Pour into a greased 9×13" aluminum or metal pan. Bake at 350°F for 20 minutes — check at 18 minutes with a toothpick. Don't open the oven early, or the cake can collapse.
4. Crema: blend the condensed milk, evaporated milk, regular milk, egg yolks, and vanilla together until smooth.
5. Once the baked cake has cooled slightly, poke small holes across the surface and pour the milk mixture evenly over the top, letting it soak in fully.
6. Meringue: beat the egg whites to soft peaks, then gradually add the sugar, beating until glossy and stiff. Beat in the vanilla.
7. Spread the meringue over the soaked cake and bake again for about 5 minutes, until the top is set and lightly firm.

Notes

Presto flour is a Puerto Rican self-rising flour brand — substitute 120 g all-purpose flour + 1.5 tsp baking powder + a pinch of salt if needed. Poking holes before pouring the crema lets the cake absorb all three milks instead of sitting on top — more holes, more even soak. Refrigerate after the final bake (the cake is very moist); keeps 3-4 days chilled.

11 · Teddy Graham Cheesecake Crust

A finer, sweeter, honey-cookie alternative to graham cracker crust — softer bite, doesn't shatter under a fork. Pairs especially well with whisky caramel or berry toppings.

Yield: one 8" crust · Active: ~15 min · Pre-bake: 10 min

VEGETARIAN

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Teddy Grahams	180 g
Unsalted butter, melted	75 g
Fine sea salt	1 g
Cinnamon (optional)	0.5 tsp
Brown sugar (optional, for extra caramel depth)	1 tbs

Method

1. Pulse the Teddy Grahams in a food processor until they reach a fine, sand-like texture — no big chunks, which create weak spots in the crust.
2. Combine the crumbs with salt (and cinnamon, if using). Add the melted butter gradually, mixing until the texture feels like damp beach sand.
3. Press firmly into the bottom of the pan only, not up the sides. Use the flat bottom of a glass for even compaction — don't over-compress, or the crust turns hard.
4. Bake at 350°F (175°C) for 10 minutes. Cool completely before filling — this locks in structure and prevents sogginess.

Notes

Teddy Grahams are already sweet — don't over-sweeten the mix. Compared to regular graham crackers: sweeter on their own, needs slightly more butter (~75 g vs ~70 g), and rarely needs added sugar. Browned butter swap: replace 15 g of the butter with browned butter for a nutty depth that pairs beautifully with whisky caramel or bourbon-based fillings. A pinch of flaky salt on the finished crust elevates the sweetness noticeably.

12 · High-End Whisky Caramel Sauce (Cheesecake Edition)

A silky, restaurant-style caramel built the classic way — dry caramel base, then butter, cream, and whisky added in sequence. Designed to accent a cheesecake slice, not dominate it.

Yield: ~350-400 g sauce · Active: ~15 min

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD · CONTAINS ALCOHOL

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Granulated sugar	200 g
Unsalted butter, room temp, cubed	90 g
Heavy cream, warmed (not hot)	160 g
Whisky (bourbon, Irish, or caramel-forward Scotch)	35-45 g
Vanilla extract	5 g (1 tsp)
Fine sea salt	2 g (0.5 tsp)

Method

1. Add the sugar to a heavy saucepan over medium heat. Don't stir — gently swirl the pan as it melts. Cook until deep amber, the color of dark honey or copper (not pale, not burnt).
2. Remove from heat and add the butter all at once, whisking until fully melted and smooth. It will bubble aggressively — this is normal.
3. Slowly pour in the warm cream while whisking continuously. Return to low heat briefly if needed to smooth it out.
4. Remove from heat and add the whisky. Return to low heat and simmer 60-90 seconds — this cooks off the harsh alcohol while keeping the aroma.
5. Remove from heat and stir in the vanilla and salt. Let cool 5-10 minutes before using.

Notes

Whisky choice matters: bourbon, Irish whisky, or a Scotch with caramel notes work best — avoid heavily peated Scotch, which will overpower the cheesecake. Serving: let the cheesecake slice sit 20-30 min at room temp, warm the sauce gently (not boiling), and spoon 1.5-2 tbsp per slice — accent, not domination. Variations: bold (45 g whisky + 1/2 tsp espresso powder), smooth & elegant (35 g whisky + 1 tbsp honey), salted (3/4 tsp salt + flaky salt on plate), or whisky orange (add 1/2 tsp orange zest). If too thick, add 1-2 tbsp warm cream; if too thin, simmer 30-60 seconds more. Keeps 2 weeks refrigerated — reheat gently.

13 · Best High-End Sauces for Cheesecake — Idea List

Quick-reference ratios for topping a cheesecake, ranked by style. Not full recipes — just the ratio, method in one line, and what it pairs with.

1. Berry Coulis (restaurant classic — never wrong)

- 250 g berries (raspberry, strawberry, or blueberry) · 60 g sugar · 10 g lemon juice. Simmer, blend, strain.
- **Best with:** NY cheesecake, vanilla bean cheesecake, Teddy Graham crust, Oreo crust (classic fruit-and-chocolate contrast).

2. Passion Fruit or Mango Coulis (bright, modern)

- 200 g passion fruit pulp or mango purée · 60 g sugar · 5 g lime juice. No heavy cooking — preserve freshness.
- **Best with:** crème fraîche cheesecake, coconut or vanilla bases.

3. Crème Anglaise (French, ultra-refined)

- 250 g milk or cream · 3 egg yolks · 60 g sugar · vanilla. Cook to nappe (82-84°C).
- **Best with:** minimalist cheesecake, thin or no-crust styles.

4. Salted Honey Cream (understated, modern)

- 120 g heavy cream · 40 g honey · pinch of salt. Warm and whisk.
- **Best with:** Teddy Graham crust, ricotta or mascarpone cheesecake.

5. Lemon Curd (bold, sharp, dramatic)

- 120 g lemon juice · 150 g sugar · 3 eggs · 80 g butter. Cook gently, strain.
- **Best with:** dense cheesecake, shortbread-style crusts.

6. White Chocolate Ganache (use sparingly)

- 200 g white chocolate · 100 g heavy cream. Thin drizzle only.
- **Best with:** berry garnish, Oreo crust (cookies-and-cream pairing).

7. Apple-Vanilla Compote (warm, autumnal)

- 300 g apples, brunoise · 40 g sugar · vanilla · a splash of lemon.
- **Best with:** spiced crusts, fall menus.

Notes

Best match for an Oreo crust specifically: the High-End Whisky Caramel Sauce (recipe 11 in this book) — the caramel and cookie play off each other well, especially with a vanilla bean filling. Berry Coulis and White Chocolate Ganache are the two options above that also pair particularly well with Oreo.

14 • Cheese Flan with Whisky-Infused Caramel

A silky, egg-forward custard flan with a true whisky caramel bottom layer (no butter or cream in the caramel itself). Scaled for a 9" round to match the same springform used for the cheesecake in this book (about 1.27× an 8" recipe by area).

Yield: one 9" round • Bake: 60-75 min • Chill: 6+ hrs, overnight best

VEGETARIAN • MAKE-AHEAD • CONTAINS ALCOHOL

Ingredients

Whisky caramel (bottom layer)

Ingredient	Amount
Granulated sugar	250 g
Water	50 g
Whisky (bourbon or Irish preferred)	44 g

Custard

Ingredient	Amount
Cream cheese, room temp	315 g
Whole milk	630 g
Eggs, whole (~5 large, no shell)	250 g
Sweetened condensed milk	150 g
Granulated sugar	75 g
Vanilla extract	6 g
Fine sea salt	1 g
Dark rum or brandy (optional, very subtle)	13 g

Method

1. Caramel: add sugar and water to a saucepan over medium heat. Cook without stirring until deep amber (dark honey or copper — too pale is weak, too dark turns bitter).
2. Remove from heat, carefully add the whisky, and swirl gently — it will bubble. Immediately pour into the flan mold and tilt to coat the bottom evenly. Let it harden.
3. Custard: beat the cream cheese gently until smooth. Add the condensed milk and sugar, then the eggs one at a time, mixing on low the whole time to avoid incorporating air.
4. Add the milk slowly, then the vanilla, salt, and optional rum. Strain through a fine sieve — this step is what makes the texture silky.
5. Pour the custard over the hardened caramel and cover loosely with foil.
6. Bake in a water bath: place the mold in a roasting pan, add hot water halfway up the sides, and bake at 325°F (160°C) for 60-75 minutes, until the center jiggles like gelatin (not liquid), the edges are set, and the internal temp reads 170-175°F (77-80°C). Don't overbake — it sets more as it cools.
7. Cool at room temp 1 hour, then refrigerate at least 6 hours (overnight gives the best texture).
8. Unmold: run a knife gently around the edges, warm the bottom briefly (hot towel or a quick pass over a flame), invert onto a plate, and let the caramel flow naturally. Don't force it.

Notes

Why whisky works here but not in cheesecake: the egg-forward custard absorbs the aroma, and the lighter dairy lets the whisky come through instead of getting buried in fat. Serving ideas: micro-grated orange zest, toasted almonds or pecans, a tiny pinch of flaky salt, or a dusting of espresso powder — serve the flan cold with the caramel at room temp for an intentional contrast. Storage: refrigerated 3-4 days; do not freeze, as the custard breaks.

15 · Sticky Toffee Pudding (Loaf Pans + Ramekins)

A 2× scaled version sized to fill two standard 1 lb loaf pans plus 2-3 ramekins, instead of an 8×8 pan. Dates soaked in boiling water (not drained) build the moisture and caramel depth of the crumb.

Yield: 2 loaf pans + 2-3 ramekins · Active: ~30 min · Bake: 35-40 min (loaf pans), 18-22 min (ramekins)

VEGETARIAN · FREEZER-FRIENDLY · MAKE-AHEAD · CONTAINS ALCOHOL

Ingredients

Pudding batter

Ingredient	Amount
Medjool dates, chopped	360 g
Boiling water	500 g
Baking soda	10 g (2 tsp)
Unsalted butter, softened	200 g
Dark brown sugar	280 g
Eggs, large	4
All-purpose flour	340 g
Baking powder	12 g (3 tsp)
Vanilla extract	2 tsp
Salt	1 tsp

Toffee sauce

Ingredient	Amount
Dark brown sugar	400 g
Heavy cream	400 g
Unsalted butter	200 g
Vanilla extract	1 tsp
Salt	1 pinch
Bourbon or dark rum (optional)	2-4 tbsp

Method

1. Chop the dates finely (smaller pieces soften faster). Pour the boiling water directly over them, then immediately add the baking soda — this helps break the dates down for a lighter crumb.
2. Let the mixture sit 10 minutes, then mash the dates right in the same bowl, water and all — don't drain anything. It should look thick, gooey, slightly chunky, and syrupy.
3. Cream the softened butter and brown sugar until fluffy. Add the eggs one at a time, mixing well after each.
4. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together separately. Fold into the butter mixture alternately with the mashed date mixture, along with the vanilla, mixing until just combined.
5. Divide the batter: split it between two greased 1 lb loaf pans, filling each about 2/3 full, then divide the remainder between 2-3 ramekins, filled 3/4 full.
6. Bake the loaf pans 35-40 minutes and the ramekins 18-22 minutes, both at 350°F (175°C), until set and a toothpick comes out clean.
7. Toffee sauce: combine the brown sugar, cream, and butter in a saucepan. Bring to a simmer, whisking, and cook 3-5 minutes until thickened. Stir in the vanilla, salt, and optional bourbon or rum.
8. Serve the warm pudding with the toffee sauce poured generously over the top.

Notes

Why loaf pans: 2/3-filled loaf pans give the same total batter capacity as the original 8×8 pan, but with less overflow risk since each pan has more headroom below the rim. Keep the date-soaking water — it extracts sugars for deeper caramel flavor, keeps the batter moist, and the baking soda needs that liquid to react and lighten the crumb. Texture check after mashing: thick, gooey, slightly chunky, pourable — like a smooth-ish date paste in syrup.

16 · Greek Yogurt Cream Cheese (Labneh)

A thick, tangy strained-yogurt spread — a legit cream cheese substitute for bagels, toast, or dips, with far more protein than the store-bought stuff. Patience is the main ingredient.

Yield: ~200-250 g from 500 g yogurt · Active: 5 min · Strain: 8-24 hrs · Keeps: ~1 week refrigerated

VEGETARIAN · HIGH PROTEIN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Full-fat Greek yogurt	500 g
Salt	0.5 tsp (≈3 g)
Lime juice, fresh (lemon works too)	1 tbsp (≈15 g)

Method

1. Combine the yogurt, salt, and lime juice in a bowl; stir until fully incorporated.
2. Line a fine-mesh strainer with 2-3 layers of cheesecloth (or a clean cotton towel) and set it over a bowl deep enough that the strainer never touches the collected whey.
3. Pour the mixture in, fold the cloth loosely over the top, and refrigerate.
4. Strain at least 8 hours; up to 24 for a firmer, denser, block-cream-cheese texture. Longer = thicker.
5. Transfer to an airtight container. Keep the whey — it's great in smoothies or bread dough.

Notes

Kirkland (Costco) Greek yogurt: works well and is already thick, so ~8 hrs is enough — but it's non-fat, so the result is lighter and tangier. Stir in 1-2 tbsp heavy cream after straining to add richness back. Finishes: honey only · honey + olive oil · honey + walnuts · honey + fresh thyme or za'atar. Protein: most casein stays in the solids. Per 100 g (non-fat base): yogurt ~10 g protein / labneh ~8-9 g — but per tablespoon it's more concentrated than the original yogurt, and carbs drop as lactose leaves with the whey.

17 · Cottage Cheese — Quick-Use Idea List

What to do with a Costco tub. Not a single recipe — a menu of high-protein uses.

High-protein snacks & breakfast

- **Sweet bowl** — top with fruit (berries, peach, pineapple) and a drizzle of honey.
- **Savory bowl** — everything bagel seasoning, cucumber, cherry tomatoes.
- **Smoothie booster** — blend into a protein smoothie; it disappears and adds creaminess.

Meals

- **Scrambled eggs** — mix in before cooking for extra-fluffy, protein-dense eggs.
- **Pasta sauce** — blend smooth with garlic and parmesan as a lighter alfredo base.
- **Lasagna filling** — substitute for ricotta 1:1; most people can't tell.
- **Quesadillas or wraps** — spread inside with spinach and salsa.

Baking

- **Flourless pancakes** — cottage cheese + eggs + oats + a banana, blended. High protein, no flour.
- **Cheesecake or muffins** — blend smooth, swap for cream cheese or ricotta.

Notes

Don't love the texture? Blend it smooth — it becomes like thick Greek yogurt and works in almost anything. Freezes OK in cooked dishes (lasagna, baked goods) but not on its own. Pairs well with hot sauce for a zero-prep savory protein hit.

18 • Berry Toast

A quick breakfast or snack: toasted bread, a creamy base, a layer of berry jelly, then fresh berries on top. Ricotta is the go-to base here — lighter and slightly sweet — with cream cheese or labneh as easy backups.

Serves: 1 • Active: ~5 min

VEGETARIAN

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Bread (whole grain, sourdough, or your favorite)	1 slice
Ricotta cheese (or cream cheese, or labneh)	30 g (2 tbsp)
Strawberry or mixed berry jelly	10 g (2 tsp)
Mixed berries (strawberries, blueberries, raspberries, blackberries)	35 g (1/4 cup)
Honey (optional)	7 g (1 tsp)

Method

1. Toast the bread to your desired crispiness.
2. Spread the ricotta evenly over the toast.
3. Spread a thin layer of berry jelly over the ricotta.
4. Arrange the mixed berries on top, slicing larger ones like strawberries for better coverage.
5. Drizzle with honey if using. Serve immediately.

Notes

Base options: ricotta (light, slightly sweet, the default here), cream cheese (richer, more tang — good backup), or labneh (thicker and tangier, also a good backup — see the Labneh recipe in this book). Other swaps if you want to experiment further: Greek yogurt, mascarpone, blended cottage cheese, nut butters, coconut yogurt, or mashed avocado all work as a base in a pinch.

19 · NY Strip Meal Prep Cubes & Air Fryer Sweet Potatoes

For breaking down a large NY strip loin: cube the portion you're eating this week (better for microwave reheating), keep the rest as whole steaks for the freezer. Seared in a cast iron pan, slightly underdone on purpose since it finishes cooking on reheat.

Yield: ~4-5 meal-prep containers per 1.5 kg beef · Active: ~30 min

HIGH PROTEIN · MEAL-PREP FRIENDLY · GLUTEN-FREE

Ingredients

Beef (meal-prep portion)

Ingredient	Amount
NY strip loin, trimmed	1.5 kg (~3 lb), cubed 1-1.25"
Fine sea salt	12 g (2 tsp)
Black pepper, cracked	3 g (1 tsp)
Avocado oil (high smoke point)	15-30 g (1-2 tbsp), for searing

Sweet potatoes (air fryer)

Ingredient	Amount
Sweet potatoes, skin on, scrubbed	800 g (~4 medium), cubed 3/4-1"
Avocado or olive oil	15 g (1 tbsp)
Fine sea salt	4 g (0.75 tsp)
Black pepper, cracked	1 g (0.25 tsp)

Method

1. Trim the loin first: remove the thick fat cap down to about 1/8-1/4" and cut away any large silverskin, before dividing the meat further.
2. Portion the loin: cut off the amount you're eating this week for cubing; slice the rest into 1-1.25" steaks for freezing (wrap individually, then bag — steaks freeze better than cubes for later flexibility).
3. Cube the meal-prep portion into 1-1.25" pieces, trimming any remaining connective tissue as you go.
4. Pat the cubes dry and season with salt and pepper right before cooking (not earlier — salting too early on small cubes draws out moisture).
5. Heat a cast iron pan over medium-high until it's genuinely hot (a drop of water should sizzle immediately). Add the oil.
6. Sear the cubes in batches, without crowding the pan, 2-3 minutes total, turning to brown multiple sides. Pull at 125-135°F internal (medium-rare to medium) — this matters, since reheating will cook it further.
7. Sweet potatoes: toss the cubes with oil, salt, and pepper. Air fry at 400°F (200°C) for 15-18 minutes, shaking the basket halfway through, until fork-tender with crisp edges.
8. Divide the seared beef and roasted sweet potatoes evenly across meal-prep containers. Cool slightly before sealing and refrigerating.

Notes

Reheating: microwave covered, with a splash of water or broth added to the container — this steams the beef slightly instead of drying it out, and helps it finish cooking evenly without turning rubbery. Skin-on sweet potatoes: leave the skin on for air frying — it crisps up, adds fiber, and saves prep time. Just scrub well first; only peel if you personally dislike the texture. Doneness logic: pulling the beef underdone (125-135°F) is intentional — microwave reheating continues cooking it, so searing to full medium now means overdone, dry meat by the time you eat it later in the week.

20 • Ground Beef Meal Prep (Rice or Sweet Potato)

A straightforward seasoned ground beef base you can pair with either dry white rice or roasted sweet potatoes, depending on what you're in the mood for. Both starch options are sized to match the beef for about 5 servings.

Yield: ~5 servings · Active: ~25-30 min

HIGH PROTEIN • MEAL-PREP FRIENDLY

Ingredients

Ground beef

Ingredient	Amount
Ground beef (80/20 or leaner)	907 g (2 lb)
Fine sea salt	8 g (1.5 tsp)
Black pepper, cracked	2 g (0.75 tsp)
Garlic powder	5 g (1.5 tsp)
Onion powder	5 g (1.5 tsp)
Smoked paprika (optional)	3 g (1 tsp)

Option A: White rice

Ingredient	Amount
Dry white rice	600 g
Water	900-960 g (1.5-1.6× rice weight)
Fine sea salt	3 g (0.5 tsp)

Option B: Sweet potatoes

Ingredient	Amount
Sweet potatoes, skin on, scrubbed	1000 g, cubed 3/4-1"
Avocado or olive oil	15 g (1 tbsp)
Fine sea salt	4 g (0.75 tsp)
Black pepper, cracked	1 g (0.25 tsp)

Method

1. Heat a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add the ground beef and break it apart with a spatula as it browns.
2. Once mostly browned, add salt, pepper, garlic powder, onion powder, and smoked paprika. Stir and cook until fully browned through, about 8-10 min total.
3. Drain off excess rendered fat, leaving just enough to keep the meat moist.
4. Option A — Rice: rinse until water runs mostly clear. Combine with water and salt in a pot, boil, then cover and simmer low 16-18 min. Rest covered 10 min, then fluff.
5. Option B — Sweet potatoes: toss cubes with oil, salt, pepper. Roast at 400°F (200°C) 25-30 min, flipping halfway. (Air fryer: 400°F, 15-18 min, shaking halfway.)
6. Divide the beef and your chosen starch evenly across 5 containers. Cool slightly before sealing and refrigerating.

Notes

Rice hydration: 1.5-1.6× water-to-rice by weight is a good start — jasmine/basmati typically need a bit less than short-grain. Both starch options are sized for the same 2 lb of beef — pick whichever you're in the mood for. Reheat covered with a splash of water to keep things from drying out. Keeps 4-5 days refrigerated; freezes up to 3 months (rice holds up better than sweet potato after freezing).

21 · Garlic-Lemon Avocado Oil Mayonnaise

A whole-egg mayo built around the classic immersion-blender emulsion — foolproof and ready in under 2 minutes. Garlic-forward, so it leans closer to an aioli than a plain mayo.

Yield: ~550-600 g (~2.5 cups) · Active: ~5 min · Keeps: 1 week refrigerated

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Large eggs, whole	2 (~100 g)
Lemon juice, fresh	15 g (1 tbsp)
Dijon mustard	10 g (2 tsp)
Garlic cloves, grated or minced	2-3 (~9 g)
Fine sea salt	3 g (0.5 tsp), to taste
Avocado oil	500 g (adjust 450-600 g for thickness)

Method

1. Crack the eggs into a wide-mouth jar or container just barely wider than your immersion blender head.
2. Add the lemon juice, Dijon mustard, garlic, and salt to the jar.
3. Pour the avocado oil on top, letting it settle above the egg mixture.
4. Insert the immersion blender all the way to the bottom of the jar. Without moving it, blend on high for 20-30 seconds — the emulsion will form at the bottom first, turning opaque and white.
5. Once the bottom third is visibly emulsified, slowly draw the blender upward while still blending, incorporating the rest of the oil until fully thick and uniform.
6. Taste and adjust: more salt for seasoning, more lemon juice for brightness, or a touch more oil if it's looser than you'd like.
7. Transfer to an airtight jar and refrigerate immediately.

Notes

Garlic strength: 2 cloves is a noticeable garlic mayo; 3 cloves pushes it into aioli territory — go with 2 if you want it more versatile as a sandwich spread. Oil ratio: 500 g oil to 2 whole eggs is the sweet spot for a stable, scoopable texture; less oil (450 g) gives a looser, pourable mayo, more (600 g) gives a stiffer, thicker one. Raw egg: use the freshest eggs you can and refrigerate promptly — this keeps about a week in the fridge, similar to store-bought mayo. If the emulsion breaks (looks thin or separated), don't panic — pour it into a fresh jar, add one more egg yolk, and repeat the blending step; the new yolk will re-emulsify the mixture.

22 · Balsamic Glaze (Reduction)

Just balsamic vinegar reduced down to a thick, syrupy glaze — no thickeners needed. Drizzle over toast, caprese, roasted vegetables, or grilled meats.

Yield: ~120 g glaze from 480 g vinegar · Active: ~20-25 min (mostly hands-off)

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Balsamic vinegar (any quality you'd drink)	480 g (2 cups)
Honey or brown sugar (optional, for sweetness)	15-20 g (1 tbsp)

Method

1. Pour the balsamic vinegar into a small saucepan (avoid reactive aluminum — stainless steel is fine).
2. Add the honey or brown sugar if using, for a rounder, less sharp glaze.
3. Bring to a gentle simmer over medium heat, then reduce to low — you want small bubbles, not a rolling boil, which can scorch the sugars.
4. Simmer uncovered for 15-20 minutes, stirring occasionally, until reduced by roughly 60-75% (from 480 g down to ~120-150 g).
5. Check doneness by coating the back of a spoon: it's ready when it clings and slowly drips rather than running off. It will thicken further as it cools, so pull it slightly before it looks fully done.
6. Cool to room temperature before transferring to a squeeze bottle or jar — it thickens significantly on cooling and will seem too thin straight off the heat.

Notes

Watch it closely in the last 5 minutes — it goes from perfect to burnt fast once it's concentrated. If it over-reduces and hardens, whisk in a splash of warm water to loosen it back up. Keeps 2-3 weeks at room temperature (it's basically preserved by acidity and sugar) or up to a couple of months refrigerated. Cheap vs good vinegar: reduction concentrates whatever you start with, so a better-quality balsamic gives a noticeably smoother glaze — but even inexpensive vinegar works fine here.

23 · Balsamic Vinaigrette

A classic 3:1 oil-to-acid emulsion, sharpened with Dijon and a touch of garlic. Good on green salads, roasted vegetables, or as a marinade.

Yield: ~215 g (~1 cup) · Active: ~5 min · Keeps: 1-2 weeks refrigerated

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Extra virgin olive oil	135 g (1/2 cup + 1 tbsp)
Balsamic vinegar	45 g (3 tbsp)
Dijon mustard	10 g (2 tsp)
Honey	10 g (2 tsp)
Garlic clove, grated (optional)	1
Fine sea salt	2 g (0.25-0.5 tsp), to taste
Black pepper, cracked	to taste

Method

1. Add the balsamic vinegar, Dijon mustard, honey, garlic (if using), salt, and pepper to a jar or bowl.
2. Whisk together (or shake, if using a jar) until the honey and mustard are fully dissolved into the vinegar.
3. While whisking continuously, slowly stream in the olive oil — this is what emulsifies the dressing instead of letting it separate.
4. Alternatively, add everything to a jar with a tight lid and shake vigorously for 20-30 seconds until thickened and combined.
5. Taste and adjust: more honey to soften the acidity, more vinegar for brightness, more salt to sharpen the flavors.
6. Store in an airtight jar in the fridge. Bring to room temperature and shake or whisk again before serving, as it will separate on standing.

Notes

Ratio to remember: 3 parts oil to 1 part vinegar is the standard vinaigrette baseline — scale it up or down keeping that ratio. The Dijon mustard does double duty as an emulsifier, not just flavor, which is why the dressing holds together better than oil and vinegar alone. For a thicker, clingier dressing (good on heartier greens), reduce the oil slightly or add an extra 5 g of Dijon.

24 · Honey Butter Sauce

A maple syrup stand-in when you're out — just butter and honey melted together. Browning the butter first gets you closer to maple's depth of flavor, but plain melted butter works fine too.

Yield: ~230 g (small batch) · Active: ~5 min · Keeps: 2-3 weeks refrigerated

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Unsalted butter	115 g (1/2 cup)
Honey	115 g (1/3 cup)
Fine sea salt	1 pinch (~0.5 g)
Vanilla extract (optional)	2 g (0.5 tsp)
Cinnamon (optional)	1 pinch

Method

1. Melt the butter in a small saucepan over low heat, or in the microwave in a heatproof bowl.
2. For a deeper, maple-like flavor: keep the butter over low-medium heat 3-4 minutes past melting, swirling occasionally, until it smells nutty and turns golden-brown with small browned specks at the bottom. Watch closely — it goes from browned to burnt fast.
3. Remove from heat and stir in the honey until fully combined and smooth.
4. Stir in the salt, and the vanilla or cinnamon if using.
5. Simmer gently 1-2 minutes if you want it slightly thickened, or use immediately while warm and pourable.

Notes

Storage: this will solidify in the fridge since butter turns solid when cold — that's expected, not a failure. Keep it in a small jar and either microwave 15-20 seconds or set the jar in a bowl of warm water to loosen it back to pourable before serving. Small-batch friendly: scale down to 55 g butter : 55 g honey for a single use without much left over. Salt matters more than it seems here — even a small pinch cuts the sweetness and makes it taste less flat, especially with unsalted butter.

25 · Spicy Honey Sauce for Pepperoni Pizza

A quick hot-honey style sauce for drizzling over pizza right after baking, so it melts into the pepperoni cups. Tangy from apple cider vinegar, similar to Mike's Hot Honey.

Yield: enough for 2-3 twelve-inch pizzas · Active: ~5 min

VEGETARIAN · MAKE-AHEAD

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Honey	120 g (6 tbsp)
Hot sauce (Frank's, Cholula, or Valentina Black)	10 g (2 tsp)
Crushed red pepper flakes	2-3 g (1-1.5 tsp)
Apple cider vinegar	5 g (1 tsp)
Smoked paprika (optional)	1 g (0.25 tsp)
Salt	1 pinch

Method

1. Warm the honey in a small pan over low heat until runny, about 30-45 seconds. Don't let it boil — just loosen it up.
2. Stir in the hot sauce, red pepper flakes, smoked paprika, and salt.
3. Add the apple cider vinegar last — this is what gives it that hot-honey tang.
4. Optional: turn off the heat and let it steep 5-10 minutes so the pepper flakes infuse further.
5. Optional: strain out the flakes for a smooth honey, or leave them in for a rustic, punchy texture.
6. Drizzle over the pizza right after baking, while it's hot enough to melt into the pepperoni cups.

Notes

Pro tips: brush a thin layer on the crust edges before baking for a glossy, caramelized finish. If using cupped pepperoni, drizzle the honey directly into the cups while the pizza is still very hot. For an elite upgrade, add a teaspoon of Calabrian chili oil alongside the honey.

26 · Kiwi Blueberry Coconut Cooler

A refreshing, tropical mocktail with muddled kiwi and blueberries, bright lemon, and coconut water.

Serves: 1 · Active: ~5 min

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · ALCOHOL-FREE

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Kiwi, peeled and sliced	1
Blueberries	60 g
Fresh lemon juice	30 ml
Coconut water	180 ml
Lemon slices, for garnish	2
Ice cubes	1 cup

Method

1. Muddle the kiwi and blueberries in the bottom of a glass or shaker until well crushed and juicy.
2. Pour in the lemon juice and stir to combine with the muddled fruit.
3. Fill the glass with ice cubes.
4. Slowly pour in the coconut water, stirring gently to combine.
5. Garnish with lemon slices and a few whole blueberries. Give it a final stir and enjoy immediately.

Notes

For a fizzier version, swap half the coconut water for sparkling water. Strain out kiwi seeds if you prefer a smoother texture.

27 · Honey Lychee Vanilla Lemonade

A bright, honey-sweetened lemon-lime cooler with a floral hit of lychee and a soft vanilla note, lengthened with coconut water instead of plain water.

Serves: 1 · Active: ~5 min

VEGETARIAN · VEGAN · ALCOHOL-FREE

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Fresh lemon juice	30 ml
Fresh lime juice	15 ml
Honey	20 ml
Lychee syrup	15 ml
Vanilla extract	0.25 tsp
Coconut water	150 ml
Water, warm (to dissolve honey)	30 ml
Lemon wheel, for garnish	1
Ice cubes	1 cup

Method

1. Stir the honey into the warm water until fully dissolved, forming a honey syrup.
2. In a glass or shaker, combine the honey syrup with the lemon juice and lime juice.
3. Add the lychee syrup and vanilla extract, stirring well to combine.
4. Fill the glass with ice cubes.
5. Top with the coconut water, stirring gently to combine all the layers.
6. Garnish with the lemon wheel and serve immediately.

Notes

Warm water helps the honey dissolve fully so it doesn't clump when it hits the cold ingredients. Lychee syrup brings sweetness and floral aroma, so taste before adding extra honey. For a fizzier finish, top with sparkling water instead of still coconut water.